

THE CHARM
OFFENSIVE: Lakshmi
Mittal (left) and Aditya



Mittal acted and reacted—whether in the dramatic announcement of his bid or in countering Dollé's introduction of Severstal and Alexey Mordashov.

At one point Mittal was in conversation with Anne Meaux, president of Image 7, once media relations chief for President Giscard d'Estaing, when her phone rang. It was Francois Pinault of the Gucci takeover fame. Pinault was irritated as he wanted Meaux in Venice but she was with Mittal in London. In a swift charm offensive, Mittal took the phone and said, "Mr Pinault, this is Lakshmi Mittal. If I could have Anne for a few more days—she is working with me on an important project." And instinctively added, "I would be very happy and grateful if you would support me when the time comes." A few weeks later, when the Europeans were raising issues of corporate governance, Mittal, who had by then met him, announced the induction of Pinault on the board of Mittal Steel. The incident is relevant because it underlines how Mittal used every occasion, adversity and even interruptions to his advantage.

At a different level the book is also a chronicle of the reluctance with which the European business community is coming to terms with the rise of India and Indian entrepreneurship. Mittal and his team have been almost candid in reliving the drama for the authors. Yes, not all of it is there and you do sense the absence of analysis. For instance, what prompted Dollé to blunder and introduce Mordashov? Or why Mittal, despite history, underestimated the French resistance. Perhaps Mittal has kept all that and more for his definitive edition. Till then there is *Cold Steel*.

E X C E R P T

Tuesday 26 October
18-19 Kensington Palace Gardens,
London

'If Guy Dollé had not been bidding, we would have paid at least a billion dollars less for Kryvorizstal,' Aditya Mittal told his father as they reflected on their latest prize over breakfast at Lakshmi's palatial home. His father nodded. It was obvious to both of them that they would continue to face

Arcelor in future bidding wars.

'It is not in our best interests, or the shareholders of Arcelor, for this battle to continue,' Aditya added. 'There are fewer opportunities for both of us going forward, so it can only get worse. We need to talk to Arcelor and come up with some form of collaboration, perhaps splitting some of the assets we are pursuing.'

'I agree,' Lakshmi said. 'Let's see if they will cooperate.' ...

Feeling bullish that he had seen off the Germans, Dollé now turned his attention to the Indians. He had responded at last to Lakshmi Mittal's invitation for a meeting.

'He's gone for 13 January,' Aditya told his father.

Lakshmi looked a little puzzled, then a familiar grin broke on his face. 'Adit, isn't the thirteenth a Friday?'

Guy Dollé was not a superstitious man. He was content that Project Tiger